Graham Beale

Design and Product Leadership · Human-Centred AI · Design Systems · Cross-Functional Practice
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Areas of expertise: Design leadership · Product design · UX strategy · Design systems · User research · Accessibility (ISO 30071-1) · Human-centred AI · Cross-functional leadership · Regulated financial services · B2B SaaS and consumer products

PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

Graham Beale is a design and product leader who makes complex systems work for the people who use them. He has built design functions from a standing start three times, at Symantec, Yell and Mimecast, and his pattern is consistent: find what an organisation is not yet ready to tackle, build the evidence to make the case, then create the team and product conditions that make good work stick. At Mimecast he gave a portfolio built through acquisition one design language through the Mimecast Elements design system, and led design through the move to an AI-first operating model. At Yell he led the research behind the move to a two-sided marketplace, which reached a touchpoint NPS of 47. His current focus is human-centred AI: the conditions that let people exercise real judgement when AI removes the technical barriers between roles, tested through his own live experiment at TurbulentGround. He is looking for a director or VP-level role where design, product and engineering work as genuine partners.

EXPERIENCE

Founder and researcher

TurbulentGround (turbulentground.com) · Independent agentic product experiment and research | July 2026 to present

- Designed and ran a live product built by a team of AI agents (product, design, engineering, analytics, QA, later growth) shipping to a production site over 17 sprints.
- Found that the agents produced correct but inconsequential output and that failures compounded unnoticed. Redesigned the operating model around a bounded human signal the agents could accept, reject or defer, with human-reviewed tickets (OpenSpec) and approvals, and set reversibility as the test for what an agent may decide alone.
- Turned the site into an ICO-registered study of how AI is changing work in product teams, with privacy by design in its data architecture; about 20 participants across a two-part beta.

Career break

March 2026 to present

- Oxford Programme in Organising for AI, Saïd Business School (2026). Continuing as an elected borough councillor and shared service board member.

User Experience Director (previously Design and Research Director)

Mimecast · B2B cybersecurity SaaS | October 2020 to March 2026

Owned UX strategy and design quality across a portfolio serving around 40,000 customers, built through acquisition and rationalised from 30 to 40 products into four key areas. Presented regularly to the CPO and CTO.

- Built three practices from the ground up: a user research function embedded across product squads, an accessibility programme with Hassell Inclusion (ISO 30071-1) that moved accessibility from post-launch fixes into design, engineering and QA, and Mimecast Elements, a shared design system held in Storybook and enforced by engineering.
- Gave a portfolio built through acquisition one navigation model and design language through Mimecast Elements, adopted as the standard across teams.
- Grew the function from four designers to eight people across design, research and accessibility, and secured and managed a budget of £300,000 to £400,000.
- Wrote the first UX strategy from interviews with all four product leaders, moving prioritisation from feature requests to outcomes; presented to the CPO and the VPs of Product.

- Led design through the move to AI-first: turned the design guild into a UX guild with product and engineering, ran tool experiments with Cursor, Figma Make and Claude, and used AI-assisted analysis of 120+ monthly support tickets to secure investment in observability.

Lead UX/UI Design Instructor

Flatiron School · Technology education | June 2019 to September 2020

- Coached more than 300 career changers through a 24-week design programme and led a two-person teaching team. Graduates joined organisations including Government Digital Service, HMRC and Starling Bank.

Head of User Experience Design

Yell · Consumer marketplace and business directory | May 2015 to June 2019

- Designed and delivered the mobile free listing sign-up for merchants with the engineering lead: sign-up had been desktop-only with a high mobile bounce rate, and the new journey matched desktop volumes without cannibalising them, effectively doubling free listings.
- Led the research behind Yell's move to a two-sided marketplace and presented it to the CEO, CTO, CMO and CPO; built the design team from zero to six and a design system still in use after leaving.

Senior Manager, User Experience

Nationwide Building Society · Consumer financial services | December 2013 to April 2015

- Led experience design for PayM and Zapp, mobile payment services built with external scheme operators, partner banks, compliance and legal, and rolled out to Nationwide's full app customer base under FCA requirements.
- Commissioned Foolproof to test both with customers before build, settling design decisions where late change was not possible.

Earlier roles

Head of User Experience, Everyclick (2012 to 2013). Principal Information Architect, Vodafone (2012). UX Team Manager, Symantec (2009 to 2012), two CEO Applause Awards including Innovation for the first iOS app. Senior Interaction Designer, Yahoo! Finance (2007 to 2009), designing a currency converter that let travellers search by country, city or resort, where every competitor used a dropdown list. Interaction Designer, BBC (2002 to 2007), leading the Radio 2 website redesign and a secondment as product manager for the BBC Radio Player.

CIVIC LEADERSHIP

Elected Borough Councillor

Cheltenham Borough Council | May 2022 to present

Re-elected in 2024. Board member of One Legal, a shared legal service for four councils, leading engagement with its case management software supplier on 27 prioritised usability and product issues.

EDUCATION AND PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- Oxford Programme in Organising for AI, Saïd Business School, 2026. Google PAIR, Hands-on AI Masterclass, 2025
- BA (Hons) Graphic Communication, First Class, Falmouth University College. Certified PRINCE2 Practitioner